lover with an arrow through his chest.[68] Perhaps she was glad to have survived the dangerous infatuations of susceptible men, and hoped to spend the rest of her life in peaceful obscurity.

And what, meanwhile, of Akbar's disapproval? Badauni records that the padishah's 'wrath knew no bounds'. When love between men was so common that even Badauni's orthodoxy didn't blink at it, why should Akbar find it so disturbing? Was it the impropriety of luring away one of his quorchis that galled the padishah? The theory might be credible, if it weren't for the fact that, soon after the Ali Quli affair began, Akbar had another of his courtiers separated from the young male dancer he had taken as companion. This courtier, Shahquli Khan, was so dismayed at his love being locked away that he 'set fire to his name . . . put on the dress of [a] yogi'[69] and retired from the world. A great deal of coaxing was required to bring him back – Bairam Khan even wrote him a ghazal – but the beloved dancer was never returned to him.

It may be pointless to speculate about Akbar's anachronistic homophobia. Still, there is something intriguing about it, particularly in a man whose male friendships would acquire legendary status – the Akbar and Birbal stories of popular culture, for example. Soon after the unhappy end of Ali Quli's tale, in the fourth year of Akbar's reign when he was seventeen, we hear of Akbar holding 'a wine party' for the first time.[70] Such assemblies would be commonplace in the years to come: Akbar's would be a garrulous court, and Akbar himself its beating heart. At the moment, however, Akbar was a beardless adolescent surrounded by Central Asian chiefs, each with more experience and clout than the other. Is it beyond belief that Akbar wanted to discourage potential romantic overtures?

An intriguing essay by Ali Anooshahr bolsters the idea. Revisiting the story of Babur and his beloved Baburi, Anooshahr notes that Babur was not indiscriminately in favour of sexual relations between men. He writes with strong disapproval, for example, about an uncle of his called Mahmud Mirza who, spying any 'comely, beardless youth in his realm' would do all he could to 'turn him into a catamite'. The point to note is that this uncle was also eyeing the kingdom of Fergana, which a pre-pubescent Babur had inherited from his father. 'Now,' writes Anooshahr, 'coupled with this threat of political subjugation by his uncle was the possibility of a sexual